Gangster Apparel

By Richard Vetere

Characters: *Louie (30s) a well-dressed hit-man, and Joey (20s-30s) his less natty partner.*
Scene: *A dingy motel room in Queens. As they prepare for a job, Louis does his best to convince Joey that clothes make the man.*

LOUIE: *(ironing pants)* Hey, where the hell you been? Another 5 minutes and I was going to call your mother!

JOEY: I'm sorry. I couldn't find the place. It's in the middle of nowhere.

LOUIE: I know. The boss picked it. He wants us to be discreet.

JOEY: We gotta talk.

LOUIE: About what?

JOEY: I don't know. . . I want to go to the beach. I want to see girls in bathing suits.

LOUIE: The last time I was on a beach I was 5 years old and I was burying some snot-nosed punk in seaweed 'cause he broke my sunglasses. I hate sand, I hate rocks in my toes, and I hate that smell that comes up from Jersey. And no matter what beach you are on, you are going to get hit with that smell that comes up from Jersey! Plus, you walk on a beach and you step on dead things. *(steps to the bed where an expensive suit lies spread across it. Louie picks up the pants and hands them gently to Joey)* Feel. *(Joey touches the pants roughly)* Make nice! *(Joey touches the pants softly)* Not any tailor. Guido on the corner near the deli. He makes the Boss's suits.

JOEY: Wow. . .

LOUIE: Georgio Armani.

JOEY: But the money it costs?

LOUIE: We are talking about clothes here. Who cares about the money? You think the Boss cares about the money?

JOEY: But he's got money.

LOUIE: He didn't always have it. He was a guy just like you and me, Joey, workin' his a** off tryin' to make something of himself.

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INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *(slick, confident) In our business, respect is everything.*
ACTOR 2: *(matter-of-fact) Respect. Loyalty. Tradition.*
ACTOR 1: *(small beat; smooths an imaginary lapel) These are the kind of guys who believe power starts in the mirror.*
ACTOR 2: *Because if you don't look like somebody . . .*
ACTOR 1: *(judging glance) You're dressed like a nobody.*
TOGETHER: *(Both freeze, subtly adjust imaginary suits at the same time) Gangster Apparel by Richard Vetere*

LOUIE: Tonight, we have things to do. *(Joey carefully carries the shirt to Louie who puts it on with the same dramatic flair he did the pants as Joey watches every movement)* The tie. On the bed. It took me a half an hour to pick the tie to match the shirt. *(Joey brings Louie the tie)* You see, they compliment each other. Silk. All I could afford was one but that doesn't matter. Watch what a tie does. Check it out. . . *(slowly puts on the tie and when the knot is complete, stands in the middle of the room like a prima ballerina waiting for applause)* Ba da bing! See?

JOEY: Wow. . .

LOUIE: The shoes. *(Joey runs to get them; brings them to Louie)*

LOUIE: Be careful! No creases! *(takes the shoes and slowly puts them on just as he did the other clothes, enjoying the act itself)* Bally. I'd have 22 pair if I could. I will someday. *(pause)* Go ahead. . . touch them. *(Joey gets on his hands and knees and touches the shoes)* I mean, Joey, they shine so nice they cry out to be kissed! Really kissed!

JOEY: They do?

LOUIE: I noticed that the other day with the Boss. He was walking out of the club, right? And I was sittin' out in the car and I watched him get into the limo and saw how his shoes were shining! I mean, I was across the street and saw them shine! *(pause)* Comb. . . *(Joey hands it to Louie. Louie combs his slicked back hair)* Fifty bucks for the haircut. I am a man on the move!

JOEY: Nice. Real nice.

LOUIE: Now, get over here. Look in the mirror. What are you thinking when you look? Huh?

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JOEY: I don't look good.

LOUIE: You got it, pal. I have been trying to tell you. . . but you don't listen. *(pause)* Just two hours in this dump and I already got dirt on my cuffs! Get me my gun. *(Joey goes to a small bag on the chair in the corner and brings it to Louie)* Go ahead. . . take it out. *(Joey takes out a brand new .38 pistol and places it on the bed)* Let's see your gun. Come on . . . *(Joey slowly takes out a worn-out .38 pistol from his belt)* What is that? What is that?

JOEY: My gun.

LOUIE: Look at it! Look!

JOEY: Come on, Louie. . . it works.

LOUIE: It works? So what, it works! How can you be seen with that? How?

JOEY: But nobody sees it.

LOUIE: Nobody sees it! I'm seeing it now! The cops who might bust you some day will see it! Come on, what's wrong with you?

JOEY: I don't know. I didn't think about it.

LOUIE: But these are the kinds of things you gotta think about! Come on, Joey. . . we started out in the same place. Running numbers back and forth to Brooklyn. . . but now who gets the good jobs, huh? Who gets the big money? Who gets the important work? Huh?

JOEY: You.

LOUIE: And 'why'?

JOEY: You are smarter.

LOUIE: And what else?

JOEY: . . . You . . . dress better?

LOUIE: I always dressed better. Even when all I could afford was a Vidal Sasson jumpsuit. . . I wore it! Every nickel in my pocket went for a pinky ring! And not just any pinky ring -- diamond! If I had 5 dollars in my pocket it went for a hair cut. Forget food! Maybe I was hungry but that's not important! I looked great! The bottom of my shoes had holes in them but they were shiny on top! Do you understand me, Joey? You tell me who you want to be. You want to be a bum or do you want to be somebody? What is that on your feet?

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JOEY: Sneakers.

LOUIE: Sneakers? Huh? Who wears sneakers? You ever see the Pope wearing sneakers? Huh? You know who wears sneakers? People who have no respect for themselves, that's who wears sneakers! And what kind of pants are those?

JOEY: These are jeans, Louie.

LOUIE: Jeans? Who wears jeans? You ever see Sinatra in jeans? Okay, you want to go casual go slacks. A nice pair of black, grey slacks -- pleated, pressed, neat. A nice button-down shirt. . . matching socks and a nice belt. The whole nine yards. The trick to casual is to look like you feel comfortable. And that jacket? A low life off the street wears sneakers, jeans, and a leather jacket with a hole in the elbow! Nobody important dresses like some kind of low life even in his own house! At home? Try a robe with a silk lining . . . good slippers! And PJ's. Silk. Always silk. The cops bust in on you and see you dressed in a nice robe with silk lining, a silk pair of PJ's and good slippers and they will treat you like somebody! You understand me, Joey? *(walks over to a suit hanging on the closet doorknob and tosses it on the bed)* There. That is for you.

JOEY: Huh?

LOUIE: Go ahead, try it on. *(Joey slowly approaches the suit in awe)* Yo! Joey, you don't examine it; you wear it! It's a suit. Had it made for you. Special. Joey, listen to me. . . tonight I change your life. You got that? Now, put it on . . . hurry. *(Joey undresses. Louie looks at his gun, Joey's gun, and shakes his head 'no'. Standing in his boxer shorts Louie hands him the pants, the socks, the shirt and tie)* Now go over it all with me.

JOEY: *(dressing)* I park the car on Bleecker.

LOUIE: Right. Bleecker faces east. . . You sit in the car. Good.

JOEY: Then at 9:15 you come walking down Bleecker toward my car.

LOUIE: Good. Then what?

JOEY: He comes out of the restaurant at 9:15. If he's got one bodyguard I blink the lights once. If he's got two bodyguards I blink the lights twice.

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LOUIE: Twice for two. *(takes his brand new pistol and puts it in his belt)* I will then walk up behind him like this... Ba ba bing! *(holds his pistol in one hand as if he is aiming at the back of someone's head. Acting it out)* And pop him twice in the back of the head. Then when the first bodyguard turns around I go bam twice right through the heart! Now, if the other bodyguard is there ready to pounce on me, what happens?

JOEY: *(acting it out)* I am right there with you, Louie. I put two slugs into him. Bam! Bam!

LOUIE: *(watching Joey)* Good. Very good. Then what?

JOEY: Back to the car we go. Nonchalant-like. Then we drive right on Broadway and left on Delancy. Then over the bridge and back to Queens. Safe and sound.

LOUIE: *(Joey, now dressed, does not seem comfortable in the expensive clothes. Louie looks him over)* You got to look comfortable in them. You just don't wear clothes, you become the clothes. It's a mental attitude. You are a somebody so walk like a somebody. You know? Look, show me how you are gonna walk up to this bodyguard. Show me. Go ahead. *(Joey bops instead of walks across the room)* No! No! You walk like that and the whole street will know you are a hood who's gonna pop some big shot!

JOEY: Then how should I walk? *(Louie walks gracefully and slowly takes out his gun)*

LOUIE: Like this. . . see? I am a man who enjoys walking. . . see? Like that. Look good doin' it. Come on, pal, don't you watch TV?

JOEY: *(looks in the mirror)* We look good. Louie. We look good!

LOUIE: *(joins Joey in the mirror)* Movie stars, or what?

JOEY: When you, Louie 'pop' a guy, what are you thinking?

LOUIE: I am thinking how fabulous I look! What else would I be thinking? It's not what is inside your head. . . It's how you look that matters! And one day when we are famous, the papers will say "Louie Falco and Joey Pugg are the two best dressed hoods in town." Let's do it.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Richard Vetere
ISBN: 978-0871297334
Publisher: Dramatic Publishing
Date (Month/Year): Sept 1996

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